left unasked is about motivation. When a client asks for a large animated scene to appear on their index page, often the motivation is a desire to seem familiar with leading-edge technology. Instead of blindly fulfilling the client's request, it is better to look for the best solution for the "Why?" A slick graphical design can say more about the client's attention to advances in technology.

Once you have asked "Why?" enough times, you should have a list of several goals for the project. These goals should suggest a set of requirements. If one of the system's goals is to generate more business, one requirement may be to raise visitor awareness of items in the client's catalog. This may evolve into a requirement that products appear throughout the site on a rotational basis. This could be implemented as banners or kickers strategically placed within the site. Don't, however, tie yourself down with design issues. This earliest stage of site development should concentrate solely on the goals of the system.

From a solid base of goals, you can begin to describe the system requirements. This usually takes the form of a requirements specification document, a formal description of the black-box behavior expected from the site. The goals will suggest a collection of functional requirements and constraints on the design. As we have said, having a goal of increasing sales suggests, among other things, that the site should raise customer awareness of catalog items. Another requirement could be that the site provide some free service to attract visitors. An example is a loan company offering a mortgage calculator. It is a good idea to informally explore possible solutions to requirements, but it's still important to keep design decisions out at this time.

The requirements specification is formal and structured, but it should be understandable by nonexperts in the implementation technology. The description of the system's behavior serves partially as a contract between the client and developer. Clear statements will eliminate misunderstandings that have a high cost later in development. That is not to say that the document should not be precise. When possible, state requirements in measurable terms. Constraining page size to 30K is an objective standard and easily tested. Requiring the

Keyword

Natural language is any language that has evolved naturally in humans through use and repetition without conscious planning or premeditation.